

Was magnitude estimation necessary?

A secondary-data reassessment of Bard, Robertson, and Sorace (1996)

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Abstract

TODO: Draft after the source and dataset inventory is verified. The likely contribution is a no-new-data reassessment of the Bard, Robertson, and Sorace measurement program: acceptability judgments are graded, measurable, and methodologically non-trivial, but magnitude estimation may not have the privileged status once claimed for it. The paper should distinguish reproduction, secondary analysis, conceptual replication, and theoretical revision.

Keywords: magnitude estimation; acceptability judgments; grammaticality judgments; secondary data; experimental syntax

1 THE PROBLEM

TODO: Open from the narrow methodological question. Bard, Robertson, and Sorace made acceptability judgments experimentally tractable by treating them as graded data, but the lasting contribution may be the formalization of judgment methodology rather than magnitude estimation itself. The paper has to ask what later data shows about that distinction.

2 THE BARD TARGET

TODO: Reconstruct the target claims before criticizing them. The candidate claims are scale resolution, fine-grained distinction, use with linguistically naive participants, replication across groups, and a stronger measurement status than simpler rating tasks. Do not depend on original participant-level data unless it's found.

3 SECONDARY-DATA DESIGN

TODO: Define four routes clearly: reproduction from published numbers, secondary analysis of later judgment data, conceptual replication of Bard's methodological claims, and theoretical revision of the acceptability construct. The paper should route each source to one of these roles before any modelling begins.

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4 SCALE AND RELIABILITY

TODO: Use later method-comparison datasets to ask whether magnitude estimation preserves information that Likert ratings or forced-choice tasks lose, whether it improves stability across participants and items, and whether the different methods change the linguistic conclusion for the same contrast.

5 THE CONTEMPORARY AFTERLIFE OF ACCEPTABILITY

TODO: Treat modern benchmark resources as an afterlife of acceptability, not as direct magnitude-estimation evidence. Resources such as BLiMP (Warstadt et al., 2020) and the Syntactic Acceptability Dataset (Juzek, 2024) show how acceptability became portable for computational evaluation, but they also change the object being measured.

6 GRAMMATICALITY AND ACCEPTABILITY

TODO: Connect the reassessment to the broader *(Un)grammatical* program. The paper should separate personal production, acceptability, naturalness, standardness, correction behaviour, and theoretical grammaticality. Existing datasets may show the boundaries of what no-new-data work can settle.

7 CONCLUSION

TODO: Conclude with the balanced update. Bard et al. were right to make acceptability measurable and methodologically serious. The case for magnitude estimation as the privileged measurement tool is a separate claim, and later evidence may support the first contribution while weakening the second.

DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

No data has been downloaded or analysed in this setup draft. The intended project uses reusable public datasets where licensing and documentation permit it; source and dataset verification are tracked in notes/source-verification.md.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

TODO: Add final AI-use disclosure with the actual model list used on the project.

REFERENCES

- Juzek, T. S. (2024). The Syntactic Acceptability Dataset (preview): A resource for machine learning and linguistic analysis of English. *Proceedings of the 2024 Joint International Conference on Computational Linguistics, Language Resources and Evaluation (LREC-COLING 2024)*, 16113–16120.
- Warstadt, A., Parrish, A., Liu, H., Mohananey, A., Peng, W., Wang, S., & Bowman, S. R. (2020). BLiMP: The benchmark of linguistic minimal pairs for English. *Transactions of the Association for Computational Linguistics*, 8, 377–392. https://doi.org/10.1162/tacl_a_00321